

Nicaragua



Nicaragua lies at the heart of Central America. The Sandinista revolution of 1978 led to 11 years of civil war between the left-wing Sandinistas and the right-wing US-backed Contras.



GEOGRAPHY

Extensive forested plains in the east. Central mountain region with many active volcanoes. The Pacific coastlands are dominated by lakes.



CLIMATE

Tropical. The lowlands are hot all year round. The mountains are cooler. Prone to occasional hurricanes.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most of the population is mixed race, and there is a large white elite. The Caribbean regions are home to communities of Miskito Amerindians and blacks, who gained autonomy in 1987. The revolution improved the status of women, but these gains have been undone by rampant poverty.

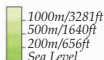


INSIGHT: Lake Nicaragua is the only freshwater lake in the world to contain marine animals



THE ECONOMY

Textiles, coffee, meat, tobacco are main exports: affected by world price fluctuations. Remittances from abroad. Substantial debt relief has cut debt to 60% of GDP. Corruption.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Nicaragua

DATE OF FORMATION: 1838

CAPITAL: Managua

POPULATION: 5.74 million

TOTAL AREA: 49,998 sq. miles
(129,494 sq. km)

DENSITY: 125 people per sq. mile)

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, English Creole, Miskito

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 80%, Protestant Evangelical 17%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 69%, White 14%, Black 8%, Amerindian 5%, Zambo 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Córdoba oro = 100 centavos